

Mahika Phutane

mahika@cs.cornell.edu • www.mahikaphutane.com

Education

- 2020 – Present **Cornell University**
PhD, Computer Science
Committee: Dr. Aditya Vashistha, Dr. Nicola Dell, Dr. Tapo Bhattacharjee
Anticipated Graduation: May 2026
- 2015 – 2020 **University of Toronto**
BSc, Computer Science
Additional Major: Communication, Culture, Information, and Technology (CCIT)
Mentors: Dr. Cosmin Munteanu, Dr. Rhonda McEwen, Dr. Daniel Zingaro

Publications

- 2025 **Phutane M.**, Vashistha A. *Disability Across Cultures: A Human-Centered Audit of Ableism in Western and Indic LLMs*. [In Review]
- 2025 **Phutane M.**, Seelam A., Vashistha A. "Cold, Calculated, and Condescending": How AI Identifies and Explains Ableism Compared to Disabled People
ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency (FAccT '25) [\[link\]](#)
- 2024 Jiang L., Jung C., **Phutane M.**, Stangl A., Azenkot S. "It's Kind of Context Dependent": Understanding Blind and Low Vision People's Video Accessibility Preferences Across Viewing Scenarios.
ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing (CHI '24) [\[link\]](#)
- 2023 **Phutane M.**, Chen N., Jung C., Azenkot S. *Speaking with My Screen Reader: Using Audio Fictions to Explore Conversational Access to Interfaces*.
ACM Conference on Computers and Accessibility (ASSETS '23) [\[link\]](#)
- 2023 Jiang L., **Phutane M.**, Azenkot S. *Beyond Audio Description: Exploring 360° Video Accessibility with Blind and Low Vision Users Through Collaborative Creation*.
ACM Conference on Computers and Accessibility (ASSETS '23) [\[link\]](#)
- 2022 **Phutane M.**, Wright J., Castro B., Shi L., Stern S., Lawson H., Azenkot S. *Tactile Materials in Practice: Understanding the Experiences of Teachers of the Visually Impaired*.
ACM Transactions on Accessible Computing, 15(3), 1-34. (TACCESS '22). [\[link\]](#)

- 2022 Heung S., **Phutane M.**, Azenkot S., Marathe M., Vashistha A. *Nothing Micro About It: Examining Ableist Microaggressions*.
ACM Conference on Computers and Accessibility (ASSETS '22). [\[link\]](#)
- 2021 Singhal T., **Phutane, M.** *Elevating Haptics: An Accessible and Contactless Elevator Concept with Tactile Mid-Air Controls*.
ACM Extended Abstracts on Human Factors in Computing (CHI EA '21). [\[link\]](#)

Honors and Fellowships

- 2023 Digital Life Initiative Doctoral Fellowship. \$5000 in research funding
- 2023 Siegel Public Interest Tech Impact Fellowship. \$10,000 in stipend
- 2020 Dennis Washington Graduate Fellowship. \$120,000
Awarded for academic excellence and strength of character in face of adversity
Full support for 5 years, including tuition, health insurance, and stipend
[Appeared in Wall Street Journal](#)
- 2020 Cornell Computer Science Department Fellowship. \$36,750
First year support awarded for outstanding application & exceptional promise
- 2017 Jackman Humanities Institute Scholar-in-Residence. \$1,000
Intensive summer residence fellowship for social science research
Curated an [Art Exhibition](#) to share research findings
- 2017 Hacking Arts: First Place. MIT Media Lab. \$2,500

Professional experience

- 2024 **Microsoft Research India.** Bengaluru, India
PhD Research Intern
- 2023 – 2024 **NYC Mayor's Office of People with Disabilities.** New York, NY
Academic Fellow
Creating an interactive AI assistant/chatbot to facilitate communication between the NYC government website and individuals with disabilities.

Invited Talks

- 2025 How AI Identifies and Explains Ableism (Paper Talk). FAccT '25, Athens, Greece
- 2024 Quantitative HCI Methods: Data & Statistics (Lecture). University of Toronto, Canada
- 2024 Conversational AI for People with Disabilities. Microsoft Research, Bangalore, India
- 2023 Speaking with My Screen Reader (Paper Talk). ASSETS '23, New York City
- 2023 LLMs and Ableism. Digital Life Initiative, Cornell Tech

Mentorship

2025	Joice Chen, Milstein Scholar, <i>Cornell</i>
2025	Oscar Wang, Milstein Scholar, <i>Cornell</i>
2024	Ananya Seelam, Research Assistant, <i>Cornell</i>
2024	Krystal Ohuabunwa, Milstein Scholar, <i>Cornell</i>
2024	Joy Alemu, Milstein Scholar, <i>Cornell</i>
2022	Cyrus West, Research Assistant, <i>Cornell</i>
2021	Ayush Srinivas, Lumiere Research Scholar
2021	Michael Ye, NSF Research Experience for Undergraduates, <i>Cornell Tech</i>
2019 – 2020	Felipe Lepecki, Research Assistant, <i>U Toronto</i>

Service and Leadership

2024 – 2025	Milstein Program in Technology and Humanity , Research Mentor Advised Milstein undergraduate scholars on independent research projects and collaborations with local NGOs.
2021	NSF Undergraduate Research Program , Research Mentor Supported a NSF REU Site with Dr. Shiri Azenkot (Cornell Tech), Dr. Steven Fiener (Columbia), and Dr. Brian Smith (Columbia), led a lecture series of good research practice and methods, and mentored upcoming undergraduate researchers.
2021	XR Access Research Seminar , Co-Organizer
2021 – 2023	CS PhD Admissions Committee , Application Reviewer

Reviewing

2025	AAAI/ACM Conference on AI, Ethics, and Society (AIES)
2024 – 2025	ACM SIGCHI Conversational User Interfaces. (CUI)
2024	ACM Computing and Sustainable Societies (COMPASS)
2024	ACM SIGCHI Designing Interactive Systems (DIS)
2021 – 2024	ACM Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI)
2022	ACM Interaction Design and Children (IDC)
2022	ACM Conference on Computer Supported Cooperative Work (CSCW)
2021 – 2022	Journal of Transactions on Accessible Computing (TACCESS)

Media & Press

2022	Online microaggressions strongly impact disabled users. <i>Cornell Chronicle</i> . [link]
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- 2021 Maestro: An AI-guided vocal coach. *Google Magenta*. [\[link\]](#)
- 2020 An accessible solution to slowing the spread of COVID. *U Waterloo News* [\[link\]](#)
- 2020 A Touchless 2020. *Yahoo News*. [\[link\]](#)
- 2020 Scholarship gives former UTM student the push to strive ... *U Toronto News* [\[link\]](#)
- 2020 Richmond student wins top North American scholarship. *Richmond News* [\[link\]](#)

Technical Skills

Programming:

Python, Java, C++, Objective C (iOS), R, Full-Stack Development, Unity

Research Methods:

Interviews, Survey, Contextual Inquiry, Ethnography, Diary Studies, Wizard-of-Oz, Thematic Analysis, Speculative Research, User-Centered Design

Design & Prototyping:

Storyboarding, Wireframing, Sketching, Photoshop, Illustrator, Premiere, Audition, Sound Engineering

AI Topics and Tools:

Data Mining, Feature Extraction, Topic Modelling, TensorFlow, PyTorch, Numpy, Pandas, Jupyter, Natural Language Toolkit, Hugging Face